Lesson 34: Future Tenses in Writing

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 13 Expressing Meaning in Future Tenses.

In this lesson

You will learn three ways to write about the future: the simple future (will and be going to), the simple present for schedules, and the present progressive for plans. You will also learn future time clauses, where a present verb has a future meaning. These forms help you write predictions and plans, for example about health care, technology or your own studies. Begin with the Pretest in your lesson material before you read on.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Form the simple future correctly with will + base verb and am/is/are going to + base verb.
- Choose will or be going to for predictions, plans, promises, decisions and invitations.
- Use the simple present for fixed schedules and the present progressive for planned actions.
- Write future time clauses with when, while, before, after, until and as soon as.
- Find and correct future verb errors in a paragraph.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
simple future	a tense for activities or situations that will happen in the future	More patients will enjoy personalized medical care ten years from now.
base verb	the simple form of a verb, with no -s, -ed or -ing	will **help**, is going to **help**
future time clause	a dependent clause (it cannot stand alone) that starts with when, while, before, after, until or as soon as and refers to the future	**When AI replaces more and more human jobs in the future**, many people will lose their job.
non-action verb	a verb for a state, not an action; it is not used in the progressive	know, like, own
pre·DIC·tion	a guess (about the future)	Will and be going to can both make predictions.
ar·ti·FI·cial in·TEL·li·gence (AI)	a technology to make machines act like humans	Artificial Intelligence (AI) has already transformed a lot of areas of our lives.
re·MOTE	far away	the remote areas of the world

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
terminally ill patient	a person who is very sick and has no chance of recovery	Medical advances are going to help terminally ill patients.
PUR·chase	buy	The hospital is going to purchase some new equipment.
SEN·ior	an old person	Those pets will make the seniors happy.

Rules and explanations

1. The simple future: forms

	"Be" verb (be)	"Do" verb (all other verbs)
will	will be	will + base verb: will help
be going to	am/is/are going to be	am/is/are going to + base verb: is going to help

- Meaning: activities or situations that will happen in the future.
- Time expressions (words that show when): later today, tomorrow, next week, in 2035, soon, in the future, in the near future.
- There will be an increased need for doctors in the remote areas of the world.
- Medical advances are going to help terminally ill patients.
- Will there be a cure for the common cold in the near future?
- Check the form. After will: only the base verb (no -s, no -ing, no extra "be"). Be going to needs all its parts: am/is/are + going + to + base verb.

2. Will or be going to?

Meaning	am/is/are going to	will
Future prediction (same)	There is going to be an increased need for doctors.	There will be an increased need for doctors.
Future schedule (same)	The new doctors are going to begin their medical practice next week.	The new doctors will begin their medical practice next week.
Prior plan (decided before now)	The hospital is going to purchase some new equipment with the donated money.	X
A future action based on strong evidence now	The patient is eating! He is going to recover!	X
Promise, desire, determination	X	No matter how long the surgery will be, this patient will endure (go through) it.
Decision made at the moment of speaking	X	A: The patient is in pain. Who will get the doctor? B: I will!

Meaning	am/is/are going to	will
Invitation	X	Will you join us in the new hospital opening ceremony tomorrow?

After "no matter how", a present verb is also correct and more common: "No matter how long the surgery is, this patient will endure it."

3. Simple present for schedules

Use the simple present for events in a fixed or official schedule (planes, movies, semesters). Common verbs: start, begin, end, finish, open, close, arrive, leave, land, take off.

- The new Children's Hospital opens next month. Its affiliated Urgent Care Center starts two months later.

4. Present progressive for plans

Use am/is/are + verb-ing for actions that are already planned, including personal plans. Add a future time expression. Common verbs: go, come, move, see, fly, play, meet, buy. Do not use non-action verbs this way.

- Dr. Marcus is flying in from New York this afternoon to perform the heart surgery. She is meeting the patient's family afterwards.

5. Future time clauses

Form: when / while / before / after / until / as soon as + subject + simple present or present progressive. The independent clause (the main clause, which can stand alone) keeps the future tense.

- When AI replaces more and more human jobs in the future, many people will lose their job.
- One of my friends will need to find another job before AI takes over her work in three months.
- She will be meeting some business friends while she is traveling next month.

The verb in the time clause looks present, but it means future. The book compares it to a Santa Claus in a shopping mall: he looks like Santa Claus, but without the costume he could be your neighbor.

Punctuation (Unit 7, Lesson 14): put a comma after a time clause that comes first. Use no comma when it comes second.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no verb "be" in present-tense sentences, so it is easy to leave "be" out of be going to. Always check that am, is or are comes before going to.

Practice

Pretest (lesson material, 10 sentences about artificial intelligence). Do it first. Compare the future verb in each sentence (bold in the book) with the options. If it is correct, choose "correct"; if not, choose the right form.

Exercise 1. Correct the future verb forms in these sentences about future houses. Example: What are homes going look like in one hundred years? Correction: What are homes going to look like in one

hundred years?

1. Some houses going to be in the outer space.
2. Some houses going to float in mid-air.
3. Are some of them going to existing under the water?
4. Most houses will still going to be on the ground.
5. What will happens to the existing homes?
6. A lecture about future homes starting at 9 am tomorrow.
7. Many students are go to that lecture.

Exercise 3. Combine the sentences into complex sentences with the conjunctions given. Each new sentence will contain a future time clause. Example: People will retire. They will enjoy more leisure time. (when) → When people retire, they will enjoy more leisure time.

1. They will save enough money. They will work hard. (after)
2. They will retire. They will not be lonely. (when)
3. They will enjoy many conveniences in daily retirement living. There will be more inventions. (when)
4. For example, robot pets will keep them company. Robot pets will be available. (as soon as)
5. Those pets will make the seniors happy. They will "adopt" the robot pets. (when)
6. The robot pets will even be by their bedside. The seniors will be sleeping. (while)

Exercise 5. In your lesson material, read "Ways Artificial Intelligence Will Change Our Lives" and fill in the 16 blanks with the verbs given (the example "will continue" is not counted). Number the blanks 1 to 16 as you go. Main clause: will or be going to. Time clause (when, whenever, while): present.

Exercise 6. "Online Learning: A Growing Trend". Correct the six more verb errors (not including the example).

Online learning will be become (will become) more popular in colleges in the next few years. In-person classes will still be dominant on college campuses, but there are going be more and more virtual learning opportunities. While many students probably did not experience this mode of education in the past, they will be grow increasingly accustomed to remote learning. It is possible that every student will has the experience of remote learning. When this will happen, more students will able to complete their study more easily. It is estimated that in five years all college students going to take at least one course online.

Speak with your tutor

- "Read me the ten predictions in Exercise 4 of my lesson material, one at a time. I will say yes or no and explain why with will or be going to. Correct my future forms."
- "Ask me about my plans for next week and my class schedule. Correct my verbs."
- "Give me six pairs of sentences to combine with when, before, after, until, while or as soon as. Check my time clauses."

- "Here are my paragraphs for the writing task: [paste]. Underline my future verbs and time clauses, then list my errors by type."

Read aloud

- There will be an increased need for doctors in the remote areas of the world.
- The patient is eating! He is going to recover!
- A: The patient is in pain. Who will get the doctor? (↘) B: I will! (stress "will")
- Will you join us in the new hospital opening ceremony tomorrow? (↗)
- When AI replaces more and more human jobs in the future, (pause) many people will lose their job.

Writing task

Book Exercise 7. Choose two topics and write one paragraph for each (8 to 10 sentences).

- What will _____ become in ten years? (education, job search, family, health care, traveling, social media ...)
- What will your life be like in ten years? What will you do to achieve these accomplishments?
- How will artificial intelligence (or another technology) help humanity in 2035?
- From Exercise 2: Will there be a cure for all types of cancer in thirty years? Why do you think so? Or: What will elderly care be like in the year 2060?

Start with a topic sentence. Use will and be going to, and at least two future time clauses in each paragraph. You may begin with NSNT free writing (Lesson 1).

Self-editing checklist:

- will + base verb (no -s, no -ing, no extra "be").
- am/is/are + going to + base verb.
- A present verb in every time clause, not will.
- A comma after a time clause that starts the sentence.
- Time expressions (in ten years, in 2035, soon) match future verbs.
- be going to for plans; will for promises and decisions.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Pretest (book): 1. will take: correct. 2. will be apply → will apply. 3. transport → will transport. 4. will use: correct. 5. will also assist: correct. 6. are going to substitute: correct. 7. is going to available → is going to be available. 8. going to use → are going to use. 9. is going to replace → replaces (time clause). 10. will take → takes (time clause).

Exercise 1 (in 1-5, will and be going to are both correct: "will float" or "are going to float")

1. Some houses are going to be in the outer space. (We usually say "in outer space", without "the".)
2. Some houses are going to float in mid-air.
3. Are some of them going to exist under the water?
4. Most houses will still be on the ground.
5. What will happen to the existing homes?
6. A lecture about future homes starts at 9 am tomorrow. (a fixed schedule; also correct: is starting, will start, is going to start)
7. Many students are going to that lecture. (a plan; also correct: are going to go to, will go to)

Exercise 3 (the clauses can also change places: with the time clause second, there is no comma)

1. After they work hard, they will save enough money.
2. When they retire, they will not be lonely.
3. When there are more inventions, they will enjoy many conveniences in daily retirement living.
4. For example, as soon as robot pets are available, they will keep them company.
5. Those pets will make the seniors happy when they "adopt" the robot pets.
6. The robot pets will even be by their bedside while the seniors are sleeping. ("while the seniors sleep" is also correct)

Exercise 5 (book; where two answers are given, both are correct)

1. will know / are going to know
2. will automatically sort / is going to automatically sort
3. will also help / is also going to help
4. provide (time clause)
5. will be / is going to be
6. will be / is going to be
7. will aid / are going to aid (the book's key says "is going to aid"; this is a mistake because the subject "interpretation ... and remote diagnosis" is plural)
8. will get / are going to get
9. performs (time clause)
10. will benefit / is going to benefit
11. simplify (time clause)

12. match (the same time clause)
13. will meet / are going to meet (also, the book's "meet to the exact needs" has an extra word: we say "meet the exact needs")
14. will give / are going to give
15. is operating / operates (time clause)
16. will surely bring / are surely going to bring

Exercise 6

1. there are going be → there are going to be (or: there will be)
2. they will be grow → they will grow (or: they are going to grow)
3. every student will has → every student will have
4. When this will happen → When this happens (time clause)
5. more students will able → more students will be able
6. all college students going to take → all college students are going to take (or: will take)

My notes